

SM 131 – BUSINESS, MARKETS, & SOCIETY COURSE OVERVIEW

Spring 2026



WELCOME!

Welcome to SM131, “Business, Markets, and Society.” We are so happy that you have chosen to join us and we are very excited to work with you this semester!

COURSE OVERVIEW

This course provides an introduction to business and to the Questrom School. The faculty team will work hard to make this course engaging, intellectually challenging, and, hopefully, extremely rewarding. Business is the protagonist in this course, but the course is about more than just business – it is a course about big ideas and about the ways that individuals, organizations, and society interact to (hopefully) enable market interactions that foster social welfare. The course’s unofficial motto is, “business as a force for good.” We see this not as an article of faith, but as an aspiration. The course helps explore the circumstances under which markets operate efficiently and inefficiently, the ways in which they enable business opportunities, and the ways in which economic and political systems and managerial choices drive business and social outcomes. It is also a survey course, which introduces the functions of business and the ethical and moral issues that business managers face. In short, we think it’s kind of a big deal.

SM131 is designed to be everyone’s first course at Questrom. We hope to establish a culture of curiosity, collaboration, and engagement among all faculty and all students. Please come fully prepared to all lectures, discussions, and workshops. (This is important, not just for your own success but in order to raise the quality of discussion for all!) Please be eager to participate in course sessions – listening actively, asking questions, and offering thoughtful comments. We are excited to work with you this semester.

A **customized copy of this syllabus** with your course instructor and TA contact information to include office hours and zoom links will be published on your specific discussion site.

SM131 COURSE COORDINATORS

<i>Content & Lecture</i>	<i>Content & Administration</i>	<i>Lead Teaching Assistants</i>
Prof. Tim Simcoe	Prof. Rebecca Nichols	Kaitlyn Miller
office = HAR643A	office = HAR648	kaitlyne@bu.edu
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email = tsimcoe@bu.edu	email = rnichols@bu.edu	Palmer Vogt
Student Availability: 2-3pm on Mondays	Student Availability:	pvogt@bu.edu
By Zoom: (link)	Tue 1-2 pm by zoom (link) Wednesday and Thursday 10-11:30 am (in person) Other times by appointment	



COURSE MATERIAL

All material will be available via the Blackboard SM 131 All Sections (Spring 2026) website (<https://learn.bu.edu/ultra/course>). You do not need to purchase a book or course pack. **This course has zero material cost.** All our required materials are available for you electronically via the course site.

Team Learning Assistant (TLA): Questrom uses the TLA (<https://teamlearning.bu.edu/>) for teaming reflection, performance and evaluation activities. This is an online program that will be employed mid- semester and used throughout your course work at Questrom.

TECHNOLOGY ACCESS AND REQUIREMENTS

The expectation is that you will have access to a computer (or tablet device) for some in-class activities. In addition, we expect you to have access to a laptop computer to take exams (the exam platform works on both MACs and Windows-based PCs but does not work on Chromebook or some iPads). If you are experiencing difficulties (of any type) securing the proper technology, please let your instructor know ASAP, so we can help you find a solution (for example we have loaner laptops for exams).

Discussion slides and Echo360 video capture recordings will be posted to our section tab after the discussions. These are not a substitute for attending class. Each student is expected to have basic competency with word processing software (e.g., Microsoft Word or Google Docs), visual presentation software (e.g., PowerPoint) and spreadsheets (Excel or Google Sheets).

COURSE OBJECTIVES

SM131 is an ambitious course, both with respect to its content and its broader objectives in the Questrom curriculum. The course's academic objectives appear below. Upon completion of this course, you will be able:

1. To explain why firms exist, what roles firms play, how firms have evolved over time, what the various functions of a business are, how firms operate in different economic, political, and social environments.
2. to apply economic principles to help firms create and capture economic value
3. to explain the conditions under which markets emerge and operate effectively; to understand the role of competition driving efficiency and innovation; to characterize the causes, consequences, and business implications of market failures; and to apply these principles to make sound managerial recommendations regarding firm value creation and capture in imperfect markets.
4. to understand the interactions between businesses, governments, and other economic stakeholders and to analyze stakeholder relationships and formulate and justify responsible and ethical managerial decisions.

In addition, completion of this course will enable students...

- **to develop and apply skills in critical and analytical thinking**
- **to develop a collaboration orientation and become comfortable working in business teams**
- **to improve real-world relevant workplace skills**, including **written and oral communication, discussion & debate, information literacy, collaboration**, and the use of software tools, e.g., **Excel**.
- **to be socialized** into the Questrom community, including understanding...
 - professional interactions among colleagues (including being a good team member & leader)
 - timely attendance
 - the use of electronics in the classroom
 - the use of Generative AI
 - professional correspondence
 - Academic Integrity
 - the use of library/information resources
 - developing as students who are **curious, collaborative, & resilient**
- **to understand the key resources of the Questrom School, including**
 - the UDC and its advising functions
 - the Feld Center
 - the Deans and Leadership of the School



This course fulfills three (3) **BU Hub Area units**:

Ethical Reasoning

1. You will be able to identify, grapple with, make a judgment about the ethical questions at stake in contemporary public debates regarding the role of business in society and the ethical decisions faced by managers with respect to their stakeholders and society. In addition, you will be able to engage in civil discussion about these topics with those who hold views different from their own. Course activities will involve multiple activities in which you will be required to formulate and represent various points of view in civil discussions. You will also be asked to pivot your position and represent multiple viewpoints regarding ethical business decision-making and to draw conclusions regarding ethical issues based on multiple frameworks.
2. You will demonstrate the skills and vocabulary needed to reflect on the ethical responsibilities that face business managers as they grapple with issues affecting both the businesses and social communities to which they belong and those identified as “others,” including rival firms, stakeholders with different perspectives, and managers from different societies. Among the considerations you will face in considering firms’ ethical decisions regard their responsibilities to and potential impact on current and future generations of humankind and Earth’s environment.
3. Your final course project will involve making assessments of the ethical behavior of firms with respect to their various stakeholders, including drawing a conclusion about the extent to which the firm acts or is able to act as a “force for good.” Note that we will not take as an article of faith that firms act as a force for good. Instead, our emphasis will be on ethical decision making applied to the question of, “for whom, if for anyone, is the firm acting as a force for good?”

Teamwork and Collaboration

1. SM131 will provide explicit training in teamwork, both in discussion sessions and workshops. You will be assigned a Project Team during the first few weeks of classes and you will work with this team over the course of the semester on two projects, each of which will culminate in presentations and Q&A sessions. You will develop a Team Contract, assess your own contributions to the team and those of others, and you will receive training and be held responsible for contributing to the team and providing feedback on the performance of all team members, including yourself. In addition, you will be trained in understanding and developing the characteristics of a well-functioning team.
2. In addition, you will be regularly placed in short-term teams for discussion-specific or multi-week mini-projects. In these teams, you will need to develop short-term relationships, structures that contribute to performance, and the ability to provide and receive instant feedback.
3. As a result of your multiple teaming experiences, you will develop the ability to use the tools and strategies of working successfully with a diverse group, such as assigning roles and responsibilities, giving and receiving feedback, and engaging in meaningful group reflection that inspires collective ownership of results. These will all be elements of your team contract and your within-semester and end-of-semester team assessments.

Research & Information Literacy

1. Students will be able to critically assess both scholarly and public-facing sources, recognizing a variety of ways that sources can be credible; use sources ethically in domains such as attribution of ideas and treatment of human subjects; and interpret and analyze information.
 2. Students will demonstrate understanding of the overall research process and its component parts. As a result, they will be able to formulate good research questions or hypotheses, use disciplinary methods of inquiry, select and deploy sources strategically to address research questions or hypotheses, and contribute to knowledge production.
- In particular, by providing training to students during Lecture, Discussion, and Workshop sessions in conjunction with information specialists from the Pardee Library, SM131 will prepare students:
 - o to access information
 - o to assess information



- o to use information ethically
- o to produce information through inquiry

COURSE COMMUNICATIONS

Communication will take place via several channels:

- Four course-wide (all sections combines) matters, our Blackboard site (**SM 131 All Sections (Spring 2026)**) will serve as our central communications link. We use the website to send announcements, post assignments and other important course information. You must become familiar with this tool and check it regularly. We will also use our Blackboard SM 131 All Sections site as a central depository for course wide lectures, announcements, and resources. You can also use email to contact the course coordinators for course-wide issues.
- For section matters, you also have access to a **SM131 All Section (Spring 2026) specific Blackboard site** for material that is relevant to your discussion section only. It will be important for you to become familiar with this page as well.

COURSE STRUCTURE

SM131 is divided into three modules:

- **Module I: Introduction to Business & Economic Value**
 - o In this first and most extensive module of the semester, we explore questions about what businesses do, what it means to create and capture value, and how business functions operate. This module will introduce the principal functions of business, including accounting, analytics, finance, information systems, management, marketing, operations, and strategy and will link each to the creation and capture of economic value. It will introduce the roles of managers and investors in operating businesses, will explain why an inexorable tension exists among them, and will identify approaches to manage this tension in the most productive possible ways. It will also provide students the opportunity to apply their conceptual understanding in a practical way by working on a team project to manage a simulated business. The module will include assignments, graded exercises, and a presentation based on your team project.
- **Module II: Introduction to Markets**
 - o In this second module, we will interrogate what it means for businesses to operate in markets. We will explore when markets exist, the conditions under which they function efficiently and inefficiently, and the problems and opportunities that arise when markets are inefficient.
- **Module III: Businesses, Society, and Ethical Decision-Making**
 - o In the final module of the semester, we will examine the roles of stakeholders in markets, including businesses, governments, NGOs, and society overall, and it will explore the ways in which these stakeholders can (and sometimes do) interact to enable business to operate as forces for good. We will also examine managerial decision-making and ethics and will consider what it means for managers to behave responsibly considering their environments and the impacts of their decisions.

SM131 meets four times per week. Attendance is expected (and will be recorded) at each meeting:

1. **Lectures (1x/week; Mondays):** Course-wide lectures meet in-person Monday mornings of each week. You must attend the section you are assigned on your course schedule. Attendance will be taken.
2. **Discussion Sections (2x/week; MW or TR):** Discussion sections meet twice per week. Discussion sections form the core of SM 131 and are run by your discussion section Professor. Attendance

will be taken during discussion and workshop.

3. **Workshop (1x/week; Fridays):** Workshops meet every Friday and are led by the course Teaching Assistants based on lessons prepared in conjunction with the Teaching Team. Workshops enhance the learning in the Lecture and Discussions. They include skill-building sessions in teaming, library/information resource usage, presentations, and more. Due to their importance to both you and your team, your grade on both the assignments and attendance will be affected by absences during Workshops.

EVALUATION AND GRADING

<u>% of Grade</u>	<u>Category</u>	<u>Date</u>
Exams		
10%	<i>Exam 1</i>	Thursday Feb 26 th
14%	<i>Exam 2 (cumulative)</i>	Monday April 6 th
24%	<i>Exam 3 (cumulative Final)</i>	Monday May 4 th 9-11 am
Team Project		
10%	<i>Team Project 1</i>	Week of March 3-5 th
15%	<i>Team Project 2</i>	Wednesday April 22 nd thru Thursday 28 th
Class Contributions*		
10%	<i>In-Class Contributions in 1st half of semester</i>	
10%	<i>In-Class Contributions in 2nd half of semester</i>	
5%	<i>Class Prep Assessments</i>	
<i>* Potential bonus of 3 points in 1st & 2nd half Class Contribution points for Financial Times engagement</i>		
Skills/Proficiency		
1%	<i>Gen AI Proficiency</i>	Friday January 30 th
1%	<i>Excel Proficiency</i>	Friday, January 30 th

If you have any questions about grades that you receive on particular assignments, you must raise them within one week of receiving your grade on that assignment. Unless we have made computational errors, we will be unable to alter grades after final grades have been determined. If you have important grade-related considerations, please raise them with your faculty as early as possible, so that they can help you approach the course in a way that will help you achieve your best possible performance.

Exams:

All exams will be administered **in person on campus. Do not schedule any travel, work or other appointments during those times.** The Exams will be intellectual decathlons, combining various kinds of questions (e.g., short written response, longer written responses, multiple choice, etc.). They will all be closed-book exams. All exams will be cumulative.

Exam schedules will only be modified for academic course/class and Varsity athletic conflicts, religious observance and disability accommodations. There are no excuses for missing an exam and students who do miss an exam should expect to receive a score of 0 on the exam.

All sections will use ExamSoft/Examplify application to administer quizzes and exams. Students will receive instructions on how to download the software to their laptops and complete the Examplify training before the first use of Examplify in class. The software works on both MACs and Windows-based PCs. If you have a Chromebook or use an iPad, please let your instructor know. A Loaner laptop can be provided for exams

by Questrom IT. All students should bring their chargers to class and exam sessions. Prior to both the midterm and final, students will receive a notice to download the encrypted exam file.

The Final Exam is scheduled for Monday May 4th from 9-11 am. Please place this date and time on your calendar. NO exams will be given prior to this date. If you find you have an academic conflict with this date, a request for a make-up exam form is located on the All-Sections Blackboard Site under Syllabus, Key Dates and Other Important Links. Requests for a makeup will be accepted until Late April. Please review the University Policy (link [HERE](#)) for a Makeup Exam prior to making your request.

Please note that, although exams collectively count for only 48% of the course grade, experience suggests that students typically achieve final grades that are consistent with their exam scores.

Writing:

As an overarching principle, we expect you to organize and communicate your ideas clearly and concisely and to present them in a professionally written and presented manner. These skills form the basis of any effective professional communication.

Class Contributions and Attendance:

Contributions to class discussions are essential to support student learning and to promote the overall learning environment. As a result, attendance at all class meetings, including lectures, discussion sections, and workshops is required, subject to the exceptions that are noted in the Attendance section of the syllabus.

Lectures will take place each Monday morning. We will make these as interactive as possible and we present both course content and valuable student-facing information in these sessions.

Discussion sections meet twice per week, either on Monday & Wednesday or Tuesday & Thursday. These sessions are taught using the case-method and most meetings will involve participatory activities. Please be sure to arrive fully prepared and to speak in class and work in a collaborative way with your faculty and fellow students.

Workshops are held by Teaching Assistants each Friday. These are critical skill-building sessions for you and for your team.

The course Blackboard site will describe the materials that you need to prepare for each class session. Please complete the **Class Prep Assessments** (CPAs) that you find on the Blackboard site prior to each session. These CPAs are designed to assess whether you are sufficiently prepared for class. Performance on these counts towards your class contributions score.

Following every class session, your contributions will be tracked and categorized in one of the four following groups. The daily scores will be totaled to produce your overall participation score, which will be **converted on a 0-100 scale representing your in-class contributions score.**

3	Strong	Made an outstanding contribution to classroom learning! Comments or questions were impactful, based on depth of your insights and/or volume of engagement. Reflected good preparation. Ideas were substantive, well supported and persuasive. Without these contributions, the quality of discussions would have diminished significantly.
2	Good!	Spoke once (or more) and substantially moved the conversation forward. Made comment(s) or question(s) that contributed in a valuable way to classroom learning.
1	OK	Made a verbal contribution of any kind to the class discussion, including an accurate answer, an interesting question, or a useful comment. (Note that most comments in class area "1's"; only a few per session will likely earn a 2 or a 3; making multiple 1 category comments will not result in movement to category 2 or 3.)
0	None	Absent or No contribution

-X	Negative	In-Class Behaviors that are disruptive, disrespectful, or in other ways harm the ability of students to gain the most they can from the class discussion (e.g., arriving late, leaving the room during class, calling out at inappropriate times, using electronics, disrespectful comments, etc.)
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We expect you to learn by actively contributing to discussions and observing your classmates participate. Neither activity is possible if you are absent; therefore, your presence in class is vital. To participate actively, you must be well prepared. This means more than just reading the assignments before coming to class. It means analyzing the issues ahead of time. We urge you to use your team to prepare before coming to class.

Please note that **quality is more important than quantity**. We consider that you are participating well when your comments reflect clear knowledge of the case and of the theoretical background provided by lectures and readings. To establish quality your instructor will consider:

- the relevance of your comments (or questions) to the topic,
- the extent to which what you say is based on thoughtful interpretation of facts,
- the clarity and depth of your reasoning,
- your willingness to "think on the spot" and engage your professor and your classmates in discussion
- the degree to which you bring issues discussed earlier in the course and other relevant experiences into our deliberations,
- the degree to which you thoughtfully participate in in-class activities,
- **the degree to which you respect everyone's right to participate and have different opinions in the discussions is absolutely critical to the success of the course.**

You will receive separate grades for Class Contributions for the 1st half of the semester and the 2nd half of the semester. In addition, we will compute a score for your Class Prep Assessments based on the total number of points you are able to accumulate during the semester.

We recognize that students have experiences in differing types of classroom environments. Please reach out to your instructor and/or TA if you would like support in making classroom contributions!

Faculty and TAs expect that you will be present in the classroom by the start of each discussion/workshop ready to engage with the content of the day. On time means you are ready before the session begins. Discussion slides will be posted to our class tab after discussion and are not a substitute for attending class.

Financial Times/Averpoint reading bonus

Students will have the opportunity to earn up to 3 bonus points on their 1st and 2nd half In-Class Contribution points by completing readings associated with the Financial Times/Averpoint system. You will receive an email with registration instructions from AVERPOINT during the first 2 full weeks of the course. In order to have your engagement tracked, you **MUST** pin the browser extension to any and all browsers you may use to engage with the reading news articles. This program/app is NOT mobile device compatible.

Mid-semester bonus will be evaluated based on reaching (and maintain) Level 4 by Saturday March 7

End-of-semester bonus will be evaluated by reaching (and maintaining) Level 6 by Saturday April 25.

*Note- non-engagement during spring break will drop your level status

Class Prep Assessments ("CPAs"):

There will be a series of Class Prep Assessments (sort of like pre-class quizzes) for each lecture. These will be administered via Blackboard. Each CPA will be due by 11pm on the Sunday night before its associated lecture. You will have 2 attempts at completion for CPA. The CPAs are a tool to ensure you are fully prepared for the lecture each week. Class Prep Assessments consist of a small number of multiple-choice or true/false questions (typically just 5 questions), chosen randomly from a larger bank of questions. These questions are designed to assess whether you are prepared for class each day. They are not designed to reflect the types of questions that would appear on an exam. They are far more focused on assessing whether you completed the readings, watched the videos, or did the exercises that were required materials

prior to class. Note that the CPAs are not a good indicator of the types of questions that will appear on exams. Instead, they are simply designed to ensure that you have done the associated Lecture Readings. **Students cannot make up CPAs if they miss them, but we will drop everyone's lowest 3 CPA scores (i.e., if you miss 2 CPAs, we would drop those two CPAs, whose scores would be zero, and your lowest score among the CPAs that you did complete).** Collectively, CPAs will count as 5% of your course grade.

Attendance

You are expected to attend every lecture, discussion, and workshop as well as certain mandatory lectures conducted by the Undergraduate Academic and/or Career Development Center (UDC). Absences are neither excused nor unexcused – they are simply absences. Your first **four absences** (from lecture, discussion and/or workshop combined) are “no questions asked” free absences. Each additional absence will lower your final course grade by two points. For example, seven total absences (three beyond the four free absences) would lower your course grade from 80 (B-) to 74 (C). You should be aware that it is possible to fail the course because of excessive absenteeism. If unusual circumstances occur (e.g., the bird flu), the student should inform their instructor and consideration will be given. Accommodations will be made for religious observances and varsity athletes. It is the student's responsibility to be pro-active and inform their faculty member in advance of any absence, e.g., days of observance or scheduled matches/meets/games. An absence does not remove your responsibility for the day's work, and the responsibility to make up for missed classes is entirely yours.

Team Projects / Presentations (2):

Learning how to work in teams is an important component of your Questrom experience and you will be introduced to teaming in SM 131. Therefore, at the beginning of the semester we will assign you to a study team. We will arrange all teams using the following ground rules with the aim of ensuring 5-7 members.

Teams are the students' responsibility to manage. Efforts must be made to resolve team issues internally. If after several attempts at internal resolution the team still needs help, go first to your TA for advice before bringing the issue to the instructor. There are resources outside of class, such as The Team Learning Center that can also provide assistance to help resolve team issues. We hope that your team functions smoothly and productively and we will do what we can to help. However, we cannot help unless you ask us to do so.

Please ask! Any change to team composition must be approved by the instructor. Approval is very rarely granted. There will be several team presentations over the course of the term. Some will be planned such as the term project for the course and some will be unplanned as part of the class exercise. The intention is to enhance your teamwork and both team and individual presentation skills.

A detailed description of the **Team Projects** is contained later in this syllabus.

GEN AI PROFICIENCY

SM131 has one required pre-assignment whose goal is to ensure that every begins their studies at the Questrom School with a basic exposure to a basic understanding of AI tools and shared understanding of AI and academic integrity and ethics. The assignment is available in Blackboard and will be due prior to the first discussion of the semester. The assignment is available in Blackboard and will be due Friday, Jan 30th. All students who complete the assignment and associated proficiency assessment prior to 1/30 will receive 1 point towards their course grade (i.e., 1/100). **Those that do not complete the assignment by 1/30 may be subject to the loss of 1 point from their course grade for each week that they are delayed in completing the assignment starting on 2/1.**

EXCEL PROFICIENCY

The goal of this assignment is to ensure that everyone in SM131 has a basic understanding of Excel and simple Excel functions. We will use these in multiple places, particularly during the weeks that focus on Accounting and Finance and in your team projects. The assignment is available in Blackboard and will be

due Friday, Jan 30th. All students who complete the assignment and associated proficiency assessment prior to 1/30 will receive 1 point towards their course grade (i.e., 1/100). **Those that do not complete the assignment by 1/30 may be subject to the loss of 1 point from their course grade for each week that they are delayed in completing the assignment starting on 2/1.**

TEACHING ASSISTANTS

Each SM 131 section has a teaching assistant. All TAs are Questrom undergraduates. Teaching Assistants will sit in on your classes, monitor your attendance, track class contributions, run Friday workshops, and in general be available to help you succeed in SM 131. TAs are there to help you; take advantage of their knowledge. But remember, following the advice of your TA does not guarantee a good grade. Your instructor, not your TA, assigns your grades. TAs will hold weekly office hours, which will be posted. Students may go to a TA anytime for help.

For a full listing of the SM 131 Teaching Assistants' Student Availability (aka office hours), please look on the All Sections Blackboard site under Syllabus, Key Dates and other important links.

GUIDANCE, TUTORIAL, ASSISTANCE WITH ADMINISTRATIVE ISSUES

Most of us need some help from time to time. Please do not hesitate to ask and to ask sooner rather than later! You should address any administrative questions to the Undergraduate Academic & Career Development Center (UDC). If your questions relate to course or other academic issues, ask your instructor to assist you.

Your instructor may refer you to the UDC who can provide you with information about tutors and other sources of help such as the LOCK Honorary Service Society. This group provides tutorial assistance tailored to SM 131 students' needs. LOCK tutors hold weekly free tutoring sessions on Monday and Wednesday evenings. One or more SM 131 Teaching Assistants will be present at most if not all of these in person sessions to provide assistance with your understanding of the course materials. The ERC provides tutors for all Boston University undergraduates (Tel: 353-7077) on all other university courses. It is best to be proactive at the start of the semester if you anticipate needing help to secure a tutor. The ERC also provides workshops on specific topics such as taking notes, success in taking a multiple choice exam and study techniques and tips.

ACCOMMODATIONS OF DISABILITIES

In keeping with University policy, any student with a disability who needs or thinks they need academic accommodations must call the Office of Disability Services at 353-3658 or stop by 19 Deerfield Street to arrange a confidential appointment with a Disability Services staff member. **Accommodation letters must be delivered in a timely fashion (and no later than 1 week before exam 1).** Please note that accommodation will not be delivered absent an official letter of accommodation.

You will find a Google Form on the ALL SECTIONS site under Syllabus, Key Dates and assignments learning module to submit your request for accommodations.

DIVERSITY & INCLUSION

In developing this course, we have aimed to be thoughtful about how identity and culture impact the course content. We invite you to share your experiences and perspectives during discussions in class. If there are topics you feel would benefit from incorporation of social context or a differing perspective, please let us know. We hope to engage a wide variety of perspectives in our classroom.

In SM131, we take pride in the fact that the cultural diversity of our classrooms gives us an opportunity to explore and appreciate the similarities and differences in how different cultures frame specific issues.

If you have concerns or ideas about diversity and inclusion at Questrom you can also reach the Questrom Diversity & Inclusion office at myQuestrom@bu.edu.

SEXUAL MISCONDUCT/TITLE IX POLICY

The Questrom School of Business is committed to fostering a safe learning environment for all members of its community and preventing sexual misconduct. All forms of sexual misconduct, including rape, acquaintance rape, sexual assault, domestic and dating violence, stalking, and sexual harassment are violations of Boston University's policies, whether they happen on campus or off campus.

Title IX of the Education Amendments of 1972 is a federal civil rights law that prohibits sex-based discrimination in federally funded education programs and activities. This law makes it clear that violence and harassment based on sex and gender is a Civil Rights offense subject to the same kinds of accountability and the same kinds of support applied to offenses against other protected categories such as race, national origin, etc. If you or someone you know has been harassed or assaulted, you can find the appropriate resources at <http://www.bu.edu/safety/sexual-misconduct>.

STUDENT HEALTH

Some students experience personal and family problems, as well as emotional difficulties, such as depression, suicidal thoughts, and anxiety, while in college. Student Health Services is available to consult with you regarding various emotional health issues that may affect you or your friends. To make an appointment, or if you are concerned about a student, call 617-353-3569. Student Health Services is located at 881 Commonwealth Avenue. For more information, visit <http://www.bu.edu/shs/behavioral-medicine/>.

COURSE RECORDING POLICY

All class sessions will be recorded for the benefit of registered students who are unable to attend live sessions due to illness or other special circumstances. Recorded sessions will be available to registered students ONLY via their password-protected Blackboard account. Students may not share such sessions with anyone not registered in the course and may certainly not repost them in a public platform. Students have the right to opt-out of being part of the class recording. Please contact your instructor or teaching assistant to discuss options for attending the course in such cases. More information on this topic is available at: <https://digital.bu.edu/lfa-classroom-recordings/>.

ACADEMIC CONDUCT

Academic integrity is an essential component of your education. We cannot overemphasize the importance of honesty and integrity in your work. Every member of the Questrom School of Business is responsible for creating an ethical environment. Please become thoroughly familiar with the University's academic conduct policy found at <https://www.bu.edu/academics/policies/academic-conduct-code/>. You will be expected to provide the Questrom Undergraduate Academic & Career Development Center (UDC) with an affirmation that you have indeed done so. If you have questions about Academic Integrity, please see your instructor!

In the past, we have had unfortunate situations where students who did not abide by the code received a failing grade in SM 131 and were subjected to a variety of additional sanctions. We hope that no students will violate the Academic Conduct Code this year, but if we discover that someone does, we will act accordingly. Academic dishonesty injures the integrity of the Program and devalues the quality of your education. The **bottom line is this - We expect you to abide by all aspects of the Academic Conduct Code!**

All work submitted to meet course requirements in SM 131, Homework Assignment, Team Project/Presentation, or other work, must be your own words and ideas, or the source must be clearly acknowledged.

Incorporating ideas or language from any source, whether copied word for word or paraphrased, is plagiarism unless the source is properly cited, and quotation marks must be used if copying text verbatim.

Delivering a presentation is similar to academic writing in that when you use findings and analysis developed by someone else as part of your assigned coursework, you must cite your source. Plagiarism is a serious breach of academic integrity, whether it is intentional or unintentional, as is the fabrication or falsification of information or sources. In addition, collaboration in the completion of assignments is not allowed unless explicitly permitted by the instructor.

Any outside assistance, including the use of professional tutors, writing services, or AI technologies such as ChatGPT, must be acknowledged upon submission of assignments. You must post the link to your AI interaction along with your Works Cited or Bibliography. (Please review the 'Appropriate use of AI' document at the rear of the syllabus)

To help you understand the expectations of Boston University and Questrom, we ask that you complete the Academic Integrity Module and submit a copy/evidence of your completion (screenshot of your scores with your name from the gradebook of the module) to your SM 131 Discussion site no later than Friday Jan 30th at 11pm.

SM 131 expressly prohibits students from posting course material of any kind (e.g., exams, course slides, descriptions of assignments, completed assignments such as papers and team projects) onto the web to be used by others. This includes posting to social media, online crowd-sourced platforms and would forbid postings to sites such as Course Hero, Slideshare or others. Any such posts would be in violation of Questrom's Academic Conduct Code as addressed in section III. N.

PROFESSIONAL CONDUCT

Class discussions will be conducted by the norms of a professional business meeting. Arriving for class after the session has begun, causing disruptions, or by exiting/entering class unnecessarily will count against your class contributions. Electronic devices will not be permitted in the classroom unless explicitly approved by your instructor.

TEAM PROJECTS:

OVERVIEW

Over the course of the semester, you will be part of a Team that will complete two projects. The **abilities (a) to deliver an effective presentation** and **(b) to work effectively on a team** are two of the most important professional skills you will develop at Questrom. These skills are relevant in many courses and professional settings and they are highly valued by employers, including those who recruit at Questrom. The Team Presentation assignment in SM131 provides an opportunity for you to begin building these essential, highly marketable skills.

Your assigned team will prepare and deliver **two projects**, each of which will culminate with a **team presentation**. Completing the projects will require extensive effort, both individually and collectively. Most of the work your team will do to prepare the presentation will happen outside of regular class sessions. Managing your team effectively will be a key to project success.

In each presentation, all team members will speak and use slides to complement and enhance the spoken content with supporting data and visual elements. You will receive feedback on your delivery/content and media use in Project 1 and we expect significant improvements for Project 2.

PROJECT #1 – Firm & Industry Analysis of Value Creation and Capture

The goals of Project #1 are (a) to introduce the company you have been assigned to your audience (b) to provide you experience with working in a team, and, most importantly, (c) to provide an opportunity to reflect upon and apply the frameworks, concepts, and principles of Module 1 of the course to a real-world company and industry context.

Presentation Component: The team presentation will involve delivery slides and a verbal presentation. Details on the verbal presentation appear below. The content of the presentation should include the following:

1. Introduction & History:

- a. introduce your firm and its industry, including the main products sold by the firm and industry
- b. identify the principal locations in which the firm and industry are located, and the key elements of the history of the firm and its industry (including their ‘origin stories,’ i.e., the innovations, regulations, or events that enabled the firm and industry to be formed)
- c. explain how big the industry and the firm are, taking care to compare them to the size of the US economy overall and to a relevant comparison industry and firm

2. Value Creation (& Capture) Analysis:

- d. provide a description of the **industry value chain** and an overview of your business’s efforts to **create value**, taking care to note the role of **specific business functions** in contributing to value creation and including a Porter’s Value Chain analysis
- b. assess the extent to which your business and the industry **create value** (over the past 5 years), taking care to compare that value creation to the economy of the country or countries in which it operates
- c. assess the extent to which your business (and rival firms in its industry) **capture value** (over the past 5 years) and your assessment of what will be most important for your firm to do to maximize its ability to capture value in the future

Presentation component scoring: The presentation will be scored based on the quality of the delivery (including team professional conduct, the clarity of exposition, eye contact with the audience, etc.) and the quality of the analysis. High quality analyses will faithfully and insightfully apply the concepts and frameworks of Module #1.

Please note that the parameters for the project are somewhat underspecified. We do not offer a template and we do not specifically cite all of the concepts and frameworks that you should apply. Instead, we offer substantial room for creativity, though we will hold the presentation to high standard

for insights based on the course frameworks and concepts and an understanding of business functions.

Logistics

The presentation should last **no more than 15 minutes**, and all team members must participate in a balanced manner. At the end of the presentation, students will respond to questions from the class and their professor for a period up to **8 minutes**.

The verbal presentation should be accompanied by **PowerPoint slides that complement** and enhance the spoken content **and a Works Cited/Bibliography** in Chicago Manual Format Word Document. The presentation and submitted slide deck must be the same. They should include approximately 7-10 slides and may not include more than **12 slides**, not counting the title and Bibliography slides) Additional guidance will be provided regarding effective design and use of slides in a presentation.

Presentation 1 slides will be due for all teams no later than 9pm on Sun-Mar 1. Teams will deliver their presentations during the week of Mar 2-5. Presentation order will be determined by your instructor.

PROJECT #2 – Company Analysis: Business as a Force for Good?

At the conclusion of Module #3, your team will demonstrate its ability to understand and apply the frameworks and concepts of the course by analyzing a company. In this presentation, as a team you will first define what a ‘force for good’ means within your firms’ industry and the firm.

Please address the following issues in your presentation:

1. Overview
 - a. remind the class about your firm, its main products, its location, and one or more of the most important elements of its history
 - b. preview the key elements of your team’s analysis in Project #2, noting, in particular, your conclusion about value capture among the stakeholders in and affected by the industry value chain
2. Mod 1 (this should be cursory as you have done this in Presentation1)
 - a. remind the class about key insights regarding value creation along the Industry Value Chain
 - b. provide an overview of firm business strategy and remind them regarding how the firm creates value
3. Mod 2
 - a. identify the economic and political systems affecting your firm and explain the impact of those systems on its behavior
 - b. identify the most important markets affecting your firm, explain whether they are highly competitive and innovative and whether they are subject to market failures and, if so, note which major government interventions address those market failures
4. Mod 3
 - a. explain your firm’s approach to corporate governance and identify any key corporate governance issues facing the firm
 - b. apply the course’s frameworks to identify which stakeholders are affected by your firm’s operations
 - c. identify the most important moral and ethical issues associated with firm’s activities and assess the firm’s performance with respect to those issues
5. Conclusion:
 - a. assess the extent to which the firm enables value capture by its various stakeholders and the extent of value capture among actors in the industry value chain
 - b. **apply course frameworks, including course ethical frameworks, to draw conclusions regarding the ways in which and the extent to which your firm is operating as a ‘force for good’ for its shareholders and other stakeholders**
 - c. identify three suggestions for (a) the firm, (b) the government, and/or (c) non-governmental actors to increase value creation and capture among industry stakeholders

Presentation component scoring: The presentation will be scored based on the quality of the delivery (including team professional conduct, the clarity of exposition, eye contact with the audience, etc.) and, the quality of the analysis. High quality analyses will faithfully and insightfully apply the concepts and frameworks of Modules #1 through #3.

Please note that the parameters for the project are somewhat underspecified. We do not offer a template and we do not specifically cite all of the concepts and frameworks that you should apply in your analysis. Instead, we offer substantial room for creativity, though we will hold the presentation to high standard for insights based on the course frameworks and concepts and an understanding of business functions.

Individual Component: Your individual grade on Project 2 will also reflect how your peers evaluate your performance on the entire assignment through TLA. Your grade may shift up or down (by as many as 50 points!) depending on your peer feedback and evaluations.

Eligible industries & firms: This semester, eligible industries and firms include:

- Telecommunications (equipment and service)
- Industrial Manufacturing & Engineering
- Aerospace & Defense
- Consumer Electronics & Appliances
- Luxury Goods & Apparel
- Media & Entertainment
- Chemicals (Industrial & Specialty)
- Logistics & Transportation (excluding Airlines)
- Professional Services & Consulting
- Video Games & Interactive Entertainment
- Fashion & Apparel
- Investment Banks
- Digital/ online Sports Entertainment
- Online Gaming

Logistics

The presentation should last **no more than 15 minutes** and all team members must participate in a balanced manner.

At the end of the presentation, student teams presenting that day will stand and respond to questions from the class and their professor for a period of approximately **25-30 minutes**

The verbal presentation should be accompanied by **PowerPoint slides that complement** and enhance the spoken content **and** a **Works Cited/Bibliography** in Chicago Manual Format Word Document. The presentation and submitted slide deck must be the same. They should include approximately 7-10 slides and may not include more than **12 slides**, not counting the title and Bibliography slides) Additional guidance will be provided regarding effective design and use of slides in a presentation.

Presentation 2 slides will be due for all teams no later than 9pm on Sunday April 19. Teams will deliver their presentations during the period of April 22 to April 28. Presentation order will be determined by your instructor.

GRADING RUBRIC FOR PROJECT 1

PRESENTATION CONTENT (70%)	Does Not Meet Expectations	Meets Expectations	Exceeds Expectations (in addition to expectations)
I. Introduction & History: - core products of firm/ind. - what events/people are evident in the creation of industry & firm - key locations for firm/ind. - firm/ind size vs. economy (25%)	Some of the key issues are addressed in the presentation, leaving the attendee with a general understanding of the firm, its industry, and their histories.	Most of the key issues are addressed in the presentation, leaving the attendee with a useful understanding of the firm, its industry, and their histories.	All of the key issues are addressed in the presentation – and the team has gone above and beyond in identifying nonobvious insights that enable attendees to obtain a deep understanding of the firm, its industry, and their histories.
II. Value Creation Analysis - industry value chain - value creation efforts & role of key business functions (including Porter VC) - analysis of extent of value creation by firm & industry (25%)	Some/none of the required topics are either not included in the presentation or are not analyzed in a way that faithfully applies SM131 frameworks.	Most of the required topics are included in the presentation and are analyzed in a way that faithfully applies SM131 frameworks.	All of the required topics are included in the presentation; all are analyzed in a way that faithfully applies SM131 frameworks; and the presentation demonstrates non-obvious insights based on the use of those frameworks.
III. Value Capture: - extent to which business & rivals capture value over past 5 years & assessment of value capture issues (15%)	Some/none of the required topics are either not included in the presentation or are not analyzed in a way that faithfully applies SM131 frameworks.	Most of the required topics are included in the presentation and are analyzed in a way that faithfully applies SM131 frameworks.	All of the required topics are included in the presentation; all are analyzed in a way that faithfully applies SM131 frameworks; and the presentation demonstrates non-obvious insights based on the use of those frameworks.
Q&A (5%)	Team members fumbled on questions / did not answer correctly. Answers not equally distributed among team.	Many team members were able to answer questions about the company. Equal distribution of answers.	All team members contributed insightfully. Answers were concise & leveraged research and applied course frameworks and critical thinking.
PRESENTATION STYLE & DELIVERY: (30%)	Does Not Meet Expectations	Meets Expectations	Exceeds Expectations (in addition to expectations)
Structure (10%)	Poor/missing team introduction and/or conclusion. Lacks thoughtful organization of content.	Introduces team, includes roadmap/agenda of presentation as well as concludes presentation in a meaningful way.	Engaging and attention-grabbing introduction, organized flow of content and includes an insightful conclusion with clear take-a-ways.
Verbal delivery, body language, & professional conduct (10%)	One or more team members were not well prepared, unprofessional, mumbled, looked at/read from slides or notecards. Limited (or no) eye contact, used distracting fillers or little body movement.	Each team member was prepared, professional, and knew their material. <u>Most</u> were clear & confident speakers. All speakers can be understood using minimal if any 'fillers' or other distractions.	Each team member was confident, engaging, professional, & well-prepared. Presented clearly and in a manner that was easy to understand & connected with the audience; used effective hand gestures, eye contact and movement within available space.
Time Management & Transitions (5%)	Team was well-over/under allotted time (> +/-60s). Fumbled with slides. Minimal or no transitions, awkward pauses or gaps between speakers	Team delivered talk within 60 seconds of their deadline. Slides advanced almost flawlessly. Team members transitioned between speakers using connecting segments	Team delivered talk within 30 seconds of time. Slides advanced flawlessly. Team members used connecting information or introductory statements to transition between presentation segments
Clarity & Visual Appeal (5%)	Slides are too sparse or too crowded. Content is not laid out well. Some slides are not readable, hard to follow, or use jargon or colloquialisms.	Unified visuals across slides. Presentation feels as one integrated narrative. Good use of color and contrast. All slides can be easily read	Slides exude professionalism. Purposeful planning (nothing missing, nothing superfluous). Left lasting impression upon audience

GRADING RUBRIC FOR PROJECT 2

PRESENTATION CONTENT (75%)	Does Not Meet Expectations	Meets Expectations	Exceeds Expectations (in addition to expectations)
I. Overview (10%) overview of presentation to include but not limited to: - intro to firm, products, location, history, & size - summary of key insights - note: should reference highlights from Pres 1	Some of the required topics are omitted or do not evidence substantial background research and/or introduction omits summary of key insights. May not have links to 1 st pres.	Most of the required topics are included (including the summary of insights) and all are presented in a way that suggests that the team invested in background research. Some links to team's 1 st presentation	Includes all topics required in Overview Presents all presented in a way that suggests that the team invested <u>heavily</u> in background research. Clear links to team's 1 st presentation.
II. Issues from Mod 1 (15%) - Industry Value Chain & value creation/capture - Bus. Functions (Mkt, OSCM, Acct & Fin and Strategy)	Some of the required topics are either not included in the presentation or are not analyzed in a way that faithfully applies SM131 frameworks.	Most of the required topics are included in the presentation and are analyzed in a way that faithfully applies SM131 frameworks.	All of the required topics are included in the presentation; all are analyzed in a way that faithfully applies SM131 frameworks; and the presentation demonstrates non-obvious insights based on 131 frameworks.
III. Issues from Mod 2 (15%) - economic/political system - key markets - market failures & govt interventions - business, govt, & other roles	Some of the required topics are either not included in the presentation or are not analyzed in a way that faithfully applies SM131 frameworks.	Most of the required topics are included in the presentation and are analyzed in a way that faithfully applies SM131 frameworks.	All of the required topics are included in the presentation; all are analyzed in a way that faithfully applies SM131 frameworks; and the presentation demonstrates non-obvious insights based on 131 frameworks.
IV. Issues from Mod 3 (15%) - governance (PA Problem) - moral/ethical issues - stakeholder analysis	Some of the required topics are either not included in the presentation or are not analyzed in a way that faithfully applies SM131 frameworks.	Most of the required topics are included in the presentation and are analyzed in a way that faithfully applies SM131 frameworks.	All of the required topics are included in the presentation; all are analyzed in a way that faithfully applies SM131 frameworks; and the presentation demonstrates non-obvious insights based on 131 frameworks.
V. Conclusions - firm & moral/ethical issues - business as force for good (re shareholders & society)? - recommendations? (15%)	Some of the required topics are either not included in the presentation or are not analyzed in a way that faithfully applies SM131 frameworks.	Most of the required topics are included in the presentation and are analyzed in a way that faithfully applies SM131 frameworks.	All of the required topics are included in the presentation; all are analyzed in a way that faithfully applies SM131 frameworks; and the presentation demonstrates non-obvious insights based on 131 frameworks.
Q&A (5%)	One or more members did not answer insightfully. One or two members dominated answers	Many team members were able to answer questions about the company in insightful ways.	All team members contributed. Answers are concise, research-based, & use frameworks insightfully.
PRESENTATION DELIVERY: (25%)	Does Not Meet Expectations	Meets Expectations	Exceeds Expectations (in addition to expectations)
Structure, Argumentation, & Research & Information Literacy - intro to presentation - conclusion to presentation - flow of content depth of research presented (10%)	Limited introduction to team & presentation issues. Insufficient intro or conclusion. Could structure content more insightfully. Could benefit from more extensive/effective research.	Complete introduction to team & presentation issues. Solid intro & conclusion. Content structured insightfully. Evidences careful background research and use of information resources.	Attention-grabbing introduction that provides a clear agenda & summary of issues & insightfully previews the conclusions, plus deep & insightful background research.
Verbal delivery, body language, & professional conduct (5%)	One or more team members were not well prepared, unprofessional, mumbled, looked at/read from slides or notecards. Minimal to no eye contact, used distracting fillers or little body movement.	Each team member was prepared, professional, and knew their material. <u>Most</u> were clear & confident speakers. All speakers can be understood using minimal if any 'fillers' or other distractions.	Each team member was confident, engaging, professional, & well-prepared. Presented clearly and in a way that was easy to understand & connected with the audience; used effective hand gestures, eye contact and movement within available space.
Time Management & Transitions (5%)	Team was well-over/under allotted time (> +/-60s). Fumbled with slides. Minimal or no transitions, awkward pauses or gaps between speakers	Team delivered talk within 60 seconds of their deadline. Slides advanced almost flawlessly. Team members transitioned between speakers using connecting segments	Team delivered talk within 30 seconds of time. Slides advanced flawlessly Team members used connecting information or introductory statements to transition between presentation segments



GRADING RUBRIC FOR PROJECT 2

Clarity & Visual Appeal (5%)	Slides are too sparse or too crowded. Content is not laid out well. Some slides are hard to read, or use jargon or colloquialisms.	Unified visuals across slides. Presentation feels as one integrated narrative. Good use of color and contrast. All slides can be easily read	Slides exude professionalism. Purposeful planning (nothing missing, nothing superfluous). Left lasting impression upon audience
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APPLICATION AND APPROPRIATE USE OF AI TOOLS IN SM 131

For all work completed in SM 131, students shall:

1. Give credit to AI tools whenever used, even if only to generate ideas rather than usable text or illustrations.
2. When using AI tools on assignments, **add** an appendix showing (a) **the entire exchange**, highlighting the most relevant sections; (b) a description of precisely which AI tools were used (e.g. BU Terrier ChatGPT, ChatGPT private subscription version or DALL-E free version), (c) an explanation of how the AI tools were used (e.g. to generate ideas, turns of phrase, elements of text, long stretches of text, lines of argument, pieces of evidence, maps of conceptual territory, illustrations of key concepts, etc.); (d) an account of why AI tools were used (e.g. to save time, to surmount writer's block, to stimulate thinking, to handle mounting stress, to clarify prose, to translate text, to experiment for fun, etc.).
3. Not use AI tools during in-class exercises or assignments, unless explicitly permitted and instructed.
4. Employ AI detection tools and originality checks prior to submission, ensuring that their submitted work is not mistakenly flagged.
5. Use AI tools wisely and intelligently, aiming to deepen understanding of subject matter and to support learning.

At the same time, this policy recognizes that your Instructor has responsibilities with generative AI also. Your Instructor shall:

1. Seek to understand how AI tools work, including their strengths and weaknesses, to optimize their value for student learning.
2. Treat work by students who declare no use of AI tools as the baseline for grading.
3. Use a lower baseline for students who declare use of AI tools, depending on how extensive the usage, while rewarding creativity, critical nuance, and the correction of inaccuracies or superficial interpretations in response to suggestions made by AI tools.
4. Employ AI detection tools to evaluate the degree to which AI tools have likely been employed.
5. **Impose a significant penalty for low-energy or unreflective reuse of material generated by AI tools and assign zero points for merely reproducing the output from AI tools.**

As students in SM 131, Business, Markets and Society, it is the hope that all students will exercise good judgement based on a sense of fairness to all and an honorable character. As our creed states, 'Truth, the only foundation for success' is at the core of this policy. Use Generative AI as a launch pad for your work, not as a substitute for your analysis or critical thinking.

This policy was adopted from the CDS Generative AI Assistance (GAIA) Policy which was crafted by students and endorsed by the CDS Academic Policy Committee. It has been adopted in CDS since March 2023.